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Amazon backs
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startup Lumotive

Rebecca Szkutak — 5:08 AM PDT · July 22, 2025



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offering a smaller more cost-effective alternative to mechanical lidar, to optical switching in places like data centers.

“It is a paradigm shift of being able to manipulate the light electronically,” Heidari said. “Being able to shape the light, to steer the light, to form the beams the way you want it, to focus the light electronically. We are able to, basically, do what mirrors and motors do today, to work around the lights.”

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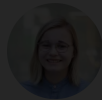


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Sweetwood Ventures
bets big on VC's smallest
funds

Despite legacy venture capital firms continuing to raise bigger and **bigger funds**, LPs may have more luck focusing on the small stuff.



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firm's potential returns compared to just investing directly, they don't take that type of stake to begin with. They've closed on two such deals so far.

"It's a no-brainer for these guys," Kurz said about approaching angel investors. "[They are] doing these deals anyway and there is this external partner that doesn't look to be a tech scout but pays them as tech scouts."



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The firm
the pea
deploy
smaller and less established firms are really
struggling to raise. Kurz said that while they were
initially apprehensive when the market conditions
started to sour, they quickly got over that fear
because they realized that the funds they back will
now be writing checks to companies at more
reasonable valuations and will actually have time to
spend on due diligence.

Kurz said when evaluating these potential investments the big question they ask, since neither the angel investor nor nano funds are big enough to lead any of the rounds they are in, is, why do startups want to take their money? He said that the firm is looking for funds and individuals that fall under two categories of answers: expertise and access.

For some, especially on the angel investor side,

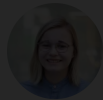


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a
new angel investor group
focused on disability and
accessibility tech

The global assistive technology market was valued at more than \$22 billion in 2023 and is projected to grow substantially by 2030. Despite the potential market size, many founders building tech to help people of early the gro

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“Venture capital firms really didn’t understand the disability community, or how big it was, or the opportunities to sell to them,” she said. “When I was talking with founders in the disability tech space, there was a similar sort of consensus that a lot of people in the startup and venture world really didn’t understand the space.”

Rich, the former co-founder of [Gravyty](#), found the same sentiment while he was working on the investing side as a managing director, and then angel investor, at Launchpad Venture Group, an angel investing group focused on tech and science-based startups.

“We knew this opportunity existed,” he said. “We were meeting incredible founders, and trying to figure out the best way to get capital to them.”



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Despite they initiated a fund and pitched numerous LPs, including impact investors and high-net-worth individuals. While they did see some traction on their original fund idea, some of that interest dried up alongside the changing narratives in the industry, and beyond, surrounding diversity, equity, and inclusion that came with the new presidential administration.

They also found that high-net-worth individuals were more interested in getting directly involved

with the startups in this space, as opposed to serving as LPs in a fund, and they started to think about building an angel group instead.

“We’ve both benefited from angel investors who took early bets on us,” Rich said. “We are both people with disabilities. We went out and we’re learning that, you know, there are no angel groups in this space. There’s no first money in that’s helping companies get from point A to point B and it’s crazy.”

Adaptation
\$250,000
co-investor
meeting
and invest
make it

There are
under the
described
expenses

Compa
someth
assistiv
also inc
access
disabili
exampl
to those
holding

Rich joked that with the pair’s collective decades of experience in the startup and investing world, they have been practicing for this new role for the last 10 years.

“I’m a brain aneurysm survivor,” he said. “I’ve had temporary and permanent disabilities as a result of that. [Brittany] is a bilateral amputee. It’s hard not



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to notice these things or hear these things about us. So we have attracted founders in this space and invested as angels for the past several years. The odds are kind of against you getting that funding, and so we almost had to do it.”

Topics: [accessibility tech](#) [Angel Investors](#)

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